

Yawnwwwn!

A known cynic once said to me, “At the bottom of it all, people are there for your entertainment.” As disconcerting an idea as it seemingly was, I gave it some thought before rejecting it entirely. “Think about it,” this person said, “the moment a friend stops being entertaining – maybe he got married, got an all-consuming job or just plain stopped being interesting enough – you unconsciously start distancing yourself from him. You’ll find yourself meeting up less frequently and eventually that out-of-sight, out-of-mind thing happens”.

If this theory is true, I suppose it could extend to other aspects of life as well, even technology. Our very existence, especially now, when base needs are taken care of, could be one big quest to stave off boredom. Think about the times you’ve turned to your phone while waiting in line, on your daily commute to work, sitting in a coffee shop, or warming the park bench waiting for your friend to turn up. God forbid, you have a moment’s idle time! It’s just not acceptable, no sir. There’s candy to be crushed, tweets to be read and gags to be loll at.

It’s amazing the amount of tech that’s created day in and day out, with the sole purpose of banishing boredom. Just take a look at our cover story – the humongous appstravaganza we’ve got in store for you this issue – for proof. While in the process of deciding what way to slice and dice these apps for you, we realised many could be simply be grouped under the overarching umbrella of “entertainment”, in other words, boredom killers.

Some people believe that there’s no excuse for boredom. With so much technology around you to keep you engaged, being bored just seems like an impossibility. I, for one, haven’t been bored ever since I got my hands on a proper smartphone. Because of so much technology all around us – smartphones, kindles, smartwatches, tablets – our mind rarely gets any idle time to just space out.

Is boredom such a plague to be avoided at all costs? An idle mind may be the devil’s workshop, but as it turns out the devil comes up with the most wickedly creative ideas. On doing a bit of digging, I found a nice podcast by New Tech City that makes a case for boredom. There’s apparently plenty of evidence to

suggest that boredom may actually be good for you. An emerging research subject called “Mind Wandering” is based on this very hypothesis. When we’re not preoccupied by attention-demanding tasks, we tend to go into a trance-like state, where we become less aware of our surroundings. Ever notice how people in a reverie get “shaken” back to reality when they’re staring into space and you happen to creep up on them? Neuroscientists have found a close link between creativity and this state we enter into when our minds are idle. A very interesting experiment conducted by Dr. Sandi Mann from the University of Central Lancashire tries to prove this. In the experiment, she bored her subjects to death (well, not literally) and then asked them to come up with creative uses for two paper cups. The most interesting ideas came from the bored subjects rather than a control group who were asked to straight away come up with ideas.

Surprising right? One would assume that constantly active (and therefore considered sharp) minds come up with the best ideas.

Now before you start sharpening your pitchforks, understand that this isn’t one of those “tech is a big, bad monster” rants. Nor am I in any way advocating a “disconnect” drive or asking you to turn into a dreadlock-sporting hippie. Quite the contrary. I think technology itself can help us be more mindful and in turn, creative. Take for example, the little discovery I made while helping with the research for the cover story – a nice app called Headspace. It guides users through short, 10-minute capsules of doing nothing; yes, meditation.

For me, Headspace was one big, accidental discovery as a result of this month’s cover story. It was perfectly in line with what I was subconsciously looking for and hence serendipitous. For you, it may be something else. On that note, here’s hoping I managed to bore you, if not a lot, then even a little, with this editorial. 



Siddharth Parwatay
Assistant Editor
siddharth.parwatay@digit.in

“Our very existence could be one big quest to stave off boredom”

Got feedback about this column?
Drop me a line at:
siddharth.parwatay@digit.in